“ Indigenous Children's

Mental Health”



By: Sara Saadat

This research paper focuses on the history of Indigenous children's mental health harmed by colonisation in Canadian residential schools and the current context of social work on the issue. The structure of the paper begins with the history of indigenous children. Finally, considering the current situation and the contributions of national law and social workers to balance the issue of indigenous children's mental health.

The phenomenological state of indigenous children's mental health is the source of the problem, pointing to the colonisation of Canada in the past few years. Before the British and French arrived on the Eastern Shores in the late 14th and early 15th centuries, generations of Aboriginal children were cared for by Aboriginal concepts and systems. Both colonial powers at the time were feudal monarchies eager to enlarge their empires with little regard for the "savages" who resided on the new lands. Although the preliminary exchange of goods and survival knowledge between Europeans was described as mutually advantageous, things quickly changed as European motivations shifted towards settlement and resource extraction (Blackstock, 2009, p. 29). Additionally, through the deliberate introduction of diseases like smallpox and tuberculosis, the expulsion of Indians from their ancestral lands, the imposition of travel restrictions on Indians, the careless exploitation of natural resources, and, after the formation of the United States of America, the federal government's Indian Act, colonial powers began their efforts to eradicate the Indian population. Besides all of that, many Indian communities, such as the Beothuk of Newfoundland, were completely eradicated because of disease, starvation, and willful murder caused by colonisation. The Indian population had decreased by 80% (or 400,000)

between the time of contact and 1871. Aboriginal children, who are also the most susceptible to disease-related death, also have to deal with the deep grief and loss that comes from losing many members of their families and communities. The loss of life was most significantly felt by Aboriginal children (Blackstock, 2009, p. 29). Indigenous Services Canada (2018) asserts that the residential school system, which began in the 1870s, was one of the most damaging assaults on the lifestyles of the Indigenous children's population. This study clearly communicates one of the mental health problems that the indigenous population, particularly indigenous children, faces. According to the dark colonisation of past years in Canada, residential schools were a place to destroy indigenous people's culture and decrease their population (Ives et al., 2020, p. 224). Those in charge attempted to destroy indigenous cultures by forcing children into the Christian churches that oversaw the residential schools. Kids were taught to practise a religion against their personal spirituality. The assimilation of Indigenous Peoples into mainstream society, focusing on the young, became the Canadian government's solution to the "Indian problem" after it was determined that physical genocide was no longer an option.

In contrast to adults, it was thought that indigenous children would have a better chance of integrating into society. The Canadian government made it against the law for Native parents to keep their kids out of residential schools at the start of the 1920s (Ives et al., 2020, p. 225). Numerous Indigenous peoples have recently come forward with their painful tales of experimentation and physical and sexual assault that occurred in residential schools. For instance, survivors recall being beaten and strapped; some students were shackled to their beds; others had needles inserted into their tongues to speak their native

languages. These abuses led to a shockingly high death toll, including overcrowding, poor sanitation, and severely inadequate food and healthcare (Hanson et al., 2020).

Furthermore, there were various attempts to reach out and heal the mental health issues that indigenous children were facing. For instance, to foster environments that support healing, conciliation, and self-determination, the Aboriginal Healing Foundation (AHF) was founded in 1998. To address the legacy of the residential school system, including physical, sexual, mental, cultural, and spiritual abuses as well as intergenerational effects, the AHF encouraged and supported Aboriginal peoples and communities in developing and reinforcing sustainable healing processes (Restoule, 2013).

The field of social work on indigenous children's mental health is working indirectly. Even though they have faced various challenges in the educational system (residential schools) for many years, it has also severely impacted children’s mental health. Developing advocacy for the education and mental health of indigenous children did not prioritise incorporating teaching methods and strategies that recognize the histories, cultures, instructional strategies, traditional languages, and ancient traditions of their societies. Therefore, social work's indirect practice is working towards a better educational system for indigenous children and youth. For instance, according to the Government of Canada, "Indigenous Services Canada (ISC) provides funding for students who ordinarily live on reserve, are 4 to 21 years of age, or the age range for elementary and secondary education support in the province of residence and are enrolled in and attending an eligible elementary or secondary program"(Government of Canada; Indigenous and Northern Affairs Canada, 2016).

Indigenous children have struggled with elevated suicide rates, murder, mental health problems, and domestic violence due to decades of colonialization, child welfare initiatives, residential schools, and intergenerational trauma. There are different national, provincial, and municipal policies that shape social work on indigenous children's mental health. There are

national Canadian organisations such as the Canadian Association of Social Workers, First Nation Child and Family Services, Supporting Inuit Children, and the Canadian Mental Health Association (CMHA). For example, the Canadian Mental Health Association defines wellness as "balance and harmony" (*Mental Health and Wellness Services for Indigenous Children and Youth*, n.d.). Additionally, they believe that wellness emphasises strengths rather than deficiencies or flaws. Being a part of a family, a community, and the natural world is important. This contrasts with some contemporary or North American treatment models, which place a greater emphasis on the individual than the community. The services of the Canadian Mental Health Association for Indigenous children and youth may include individual and group therapy, cyber-counseling by e-mail or live chat, and crisis intervention to improve and balance their mental health in a positive manner. According to Lopez-Carmen et al., (2019) Indigenous children's mental health, though still in its infancy, is already demonstrating promise for enhancing the well-being of Indigenous children, their spouses and children, and social systems, as well as their own contentment with and use of medical and social services.

The mental illnesses that Indigenous children who attended residential schools established in Canada because of colonisation experienced in the previous year in addition,

the Indian residential school system was based on the clearly stated goals of assimilating Indians, which were deemed to be the most effective way to "civilise" the Indians (Blackstock, 2009, p.30). Despite the present state of the indigenous population, especially children's, mental health issues and its context, social workers, other people, and Canadian government entities have also found a solution and a satisfactory method of implementing the plan, such as the Canadian Mental Health Association (CMHA), which provides its service towards the wellness of indigenous people and communities in balance and harmony. A positive outcome of

challenging work towards a goal can lead to better results in the future. According to Lopez-Carmen et al. (2019), Indigenous children's mental health is improving, which positively impacts their well-being and the use of medical and social services in today’s world.

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